Kevin Casas Chapter Rewrite Critique

Emily Beckler

I really liked what you have done with this rewrite, I think that that it was a smart decision to focus on the first half of the chapter and lengthen that out with some more detail.

I liked the section that you added in the beginning, where you elaborated on Lucas's dream with the Voice - I think the concept of a maze was a nice touch. With this section, I did wonder what the Voice sounds like - are you purposefully withholding description? Especially knowing that the Voice is attached to a character that we're going to meet in the next chapter, I would have liked some more description of how it sounds and what Lucas thinks of it.

I also really liked the added information about what the campus looks like, and how you sort of gave us a feel for your conception of this place. I do think that with the slight time skip between this and the dramatic ending of chapter one, that there should be some added exposition about Lucas's transition to the school. How did he come to be here? You noted that he can talk to his friends and family but can't mention magic - what is is his explanation to them for basically dropping off the face of the earth? Also, I would have loved a few more details about his outsider status as the only "sparked" student - perhaps we could see an instance of ostracization from other students that gives us that needed exposition. You drop a few hints, but I think solidifying that status through the narrative in this chapter will make the big reveal in the next chapter more dramatic for the reader.

This relates to my final critique, which involves Lucas's talk with Caleb's apparition. I like the concept of this scene and wouldn't say that it should be taken out, but I think it becomes a bit exposition-heavy at points, kind of feeling like an info-dump monologue. I think if you rework some of that exposition (Lucas feeling like an outsider, his difficulty with this

transition) earlier into the chapter, then it will make this conversation feel more natural and organic.

Once again, I think you did such a nice job with Jason's character, and that entire scene of his and Lucas's interaction. I would love to see even more conversation between him and Lucas, that demonstrated more of Lucas's character and how he interacts with people. This chapter also had nice flow and pacing - nothing seemed to drag on or move by too quickly. Your phrasing can be repetitive in places, which I have noted on the line edit.

On the whole, I think you did a really nice job with this rewrite! I really liked the decision to focus in more on the first half of your initial submission as its own chapter. I'm excited to discuss it in class tomorrow!

Kevin,

Nicely done! Overall, I like the edits and the slowed-down pace of the training sequence. I think you do a good job showing us what's going on in Lucas's head, while keeping up a compelling pace.

One thing I think you can do to dramatize this scene is really play up the difference between Jason and Caleb in their tutoring styles. It's clear that Caleb is more cautious, and Jason is more risk-taking, but I think you can really show that off here and have our hero Lucas caught in the middle. Maybe at first Lucas is hesitant about Jason's more combative style. He likes and trusts Caleb and doesn't really trust Jason's sudden friendliness towards him. But then Jason's style works! And Lucas learns more things, more quickly. He throws himself into this once Jason leaves, imagining fake enemies. But he can't shake the nagging feeling that he's cheating… You're already doing this to a degree, but I'd like more of it.

I'd like to also see you ramp up the tension while Jason is there. Have Lucas be a little more suspicious of why Jason's suddenly being so friendly. Is it because Jason sees what powers Lucas has and wants to use them? Because he's trying to recruit Lucas to something? Or maybe make Jason less friendly and have a confrontation over why. I'd like to understand or suspect Jason's motivations one way or the other, and have Lucas trying to puzzle this out and where he fits into the larger community; I think that would do an even better job than you've already done of framing this scene in the larger story.

I'm also a little confused by the inconsistency of Lucas suddenly being able to form a full illusion of Caleb, from barely being able to concentrate light in his hands. What happens to change that, since Jason isn't throwing something at him anymore? Is the adrenaline still

flowing, allowing him to channel greater power? Does he envision a more combative scenario, which does the same thing? I'd just like a little more explanation for this sudden leap in ability.

I'm assuming you'll explain this in later chapters, but I'd like to eventually learn why the Voice chose Lucas in particular, considering he's not super competent at magic, as the one who should save it. Because of Lucas's sparked nature is it easier for the Voice to establish a connection with him, for example?

Also, one small suggestion: The Voice isn't giving any details of how Lucas can help or where Lucas should go to help it. Maybe you can have it say *something*, but it comes out garbled and incomprehensible, or frustratingly vague. I'm thinking like how in Harry Potter 1, they spent months trying to figure out who Nicolas Flamel was. There's a clue to where he is – for example, maybe the Voice is in Waldover's Glen in the forest, or some such, and keeps saying Waldover, but Lucas doesn't know what it is and it's not on Google maps since it's an archaic location known only among magical people. Maybe Lucas even cautiously asks Caleb about it, but Caleb doesn't know what it means and then gets suspicious/worried. I dunno, there's stuff you could do there!

I really like your system of magic! I'd love to read the other chapters and get more insight into this world!

Best,

Elizabeth

Kevin Casas Peer Critique, form Meredith Dietz

Wow. This rewrite is such a drastic improvement from your original submission, it's going to be hard for me to find a productive critique! Not only did you take in stylistic line edits, but you also reworked the pacing and overall structure. Your prose is more polished, you take greater care to build tension, and Lucas himself really shone as a distinct character this chapter. It's clear that you poured a lot of care into the revision process, and I believe it truly paid off!

My favorite addition to this chapter, of course, is your description of how the powers physically work. It brought a smile to my face to read the way that he "warmth spread across his torso and arms, causing them to radiate shimmering light, before he pushed the light to encompass his head and lower body." If anything, one my critiques might be more of a request: include even more description of how the powers feel! I know that the shield against Jason is meant to be sudden, instinctual; is it still possible to describe how that gut-instinct felt to Lucas?

Personally, I enjoyed the longer dream sequence at the beginning – it reminded me a lot of *The Order of the Phoenix* (which was my favorite book growing up). This sort of suspense will serve for a more satisfying moment when Lucas discoveries the mysterious meaning of these dreams.

Then, my other major area of praise is how Lucas's character has developed consistency and personality. His inner quest shines through lines like, "*Don't explode*." Even outside of his powers, you've managed to make

his anxiety more central to his personality! Like with your line, “He stared at the text message until the backlight on his phone dimmed. Lucas erased it and typed a new message.” Such relatable content! All of this makes me wonder if “harnessing” (rather than “overcoming”) his anxiety will be his major character development, and what sort of message this could imply about mental health. I’d be interested to hear your thoughts!

Overall, you made a lot of wise decisions to give this part of your story more believe pacing. My only critique is to take a break from your work, and then revisit it with a fresh pair of eyes. This always helps me cut out parts that come across as more “telling” than “showing” (a struggle that all of us need to work on). In terms of plot, I’m not sure what you now intend to be the climactic moment – is it discovering the Voice’s identity? Or will that moment be the catalyst for a new quest? Regardless, keep exercising your authorly patience so that you continue to build suspense. Keep it up!

I’m looking forward to splitting class time between the two of us! My apologies for the lack of criticism

Thanks again,

Meredith

Julia Piraino 3/31/19

ENGL 3378 Critique of Kevin Casas Revision

Dear Kevin,

This is a great improvement from your first draft! I love the way you've physicalized the magic—the light being a warm thing in Lucas's chest that he can extend from there with great effort, and the headaches indicating an uncontrollable surge of his power. I'd like a little more description of the light itself—is it white? Gold? Or can the magic user change its color? Maybe that's something Jason could do to show off. When the likeness of Caleb appears, how is it postured? What is its expression? Has Lucas ever tried to adjust those things about likenesses, or are they always sort of stoic and portrait-like?

I like Lucas's reflection on his family and friends—how much he misses them, how difficult it is to communicate with them. I feel like at this point in the book, he probably would have had a conversation or two with his family and friends. I think you should include those scenes in earlier chapters, and then you have less explaining to do here to justify the emotions he feels when Julia and Katherine enter his mind.

Similarly, I think a lot of what Lucas says to his Caleb illusion is a little bit of a backstory dump that your readers may not need at this point in the story. I get that he's sort of summarizing the narrative of how Caleb came to mean so much to him, but consider shortening that just a little and replacing it with descriptions of Lucas's actions and emotions.

Other than that, my comments were just minor rephrasing suggestions. I find it awkward to use the same word twice in a sentence ("the light…was lighting the way"), so perhaps avoid that when possible. And omit unnecessary words ("there was a cold wind that blew—a cold wind blew; "the clearing that they used when they practiced"—the clearing where they practiced.) I

love where this has gone and I'd love to see what you do with the other half of the original chapter, if you get around to it!

Best of luck,

Julia

Erin Norris ENGL 3378

Rewrite Critique For: Kevin Casas

Hey, Kevin! Right off the bat, I could tell that you really took our advice when it came to fleshing out Lucas' dream and providing more descriptors – reading the opening words to your chapter felt immediately more immersive than it did the previous time. In general, your descriptions have improved – we can now see that Lucas is waking pup, traveling across campus, doing mundane things like putting his shoes on. I would love to see more description as to how things look on the quad, depending on the length of your chapter – it could also be a good way to set up any secondary characters that you may want to introduce later (less of a critique and more of a suggestion). The way you describe Lucas's powers in this chapter reminds me a little of *Runaways'* Karolina Dean – if you're looking for some technicolor visual inspiration, I'd look her up. It was generally good; I think I would want to see more description as to how it feels, but seeing as this chapter comes far later in the book, that might not be necessary.

I do think that a few times you edge towards telling and not showing – for example, you mention Lucas avoiding though spirals at both the beginning and end of the chapter. While I totally knew what you meant, I think describing how Lucas tends to get caught up in those patterns of thought at least the first time you mention this phrasing could be really helpful in relating that particular action to his character, and why you would want to avoid it. Instead of focusing on just the rhetorical questions when he begins to spiral, I would break up the barrage of questions with his physiological reactions – maybe he grits his teeth or clenches his fists together at certain thoughts! I think that fleshing those kinds of things out could better serve your chapter as you move forward. I look forward to discussing this with you in the morning!

Samantha Crimmins

Kevin Casas

Critique 3

Dear Kevin,

It seems like you've given the Voice more to say! I think that, as well as establishing in as part of a dream sequence, has helped it fit into a norm in Lucas' life more! At first, I think we talked about the Voice being a little too direct of a way to move the plot forward, but now it reads more like a relationship. If you don't have a plan for the man behind the Voice yet, something that you may consider is having this be the headmaster or a detained professor or someone who Lucas wouldn't have been able to interact with earlier, but has some special interest in his well-being. Sort of like Bo and Trick if you've ever seen Lost Girl.

Something else that you may find some random inspiration from is the Waldorf education system. I know that sounds wonky, but hear me out! You're voice says things like "learn" and "grow". These are major things in the Waldorf environment where, instead of saying the pledge of allegiance, we'd recite a morning mantra that included similar lines about learning, working, and growth. You should check it out!

I've made this critique before, and I feel like it's important to keep in mind still, but be very careful about overlapping with other works. Magic is difficult now because JK Rowling basically set the worldwide standard.

Whenever magic is introduced in a modern context and being taught at a magical-specific school, Harry Potter will inevitably surface in readers minds. You did a great job making the Voice your own, but the splitting headaches and using the dreams as a guide or window into what's happening in the real world are also very reminiscent of Harry Potter. On a similar note, you're in a genre that goes up against other authors with global recognition because their work was adapted into a film. Specifically, I'm referencing the Maze Runner series. It has a very different plot, but the maze scene that you use here reads very similar to what James Dashner wrote.

One other critique I wanted to focus on was your dialogue. There are a lot of important ideas in them that did need to be communicated, but some of the conversations read a little it dry. For example, you write:

"Sounds like a snore-fest," Jason groaned, "But I'm already here, and it seems like you can use all the help you can get. Let's see what you've got." This could possibly be improved by doing more of a show than tell. If Lucas was feeling real grateful and thanking Jason for helping him and Jason looks up at him, gives a hardy thumbs up, rolls his eyes, and starts tearing up a piece of paper; I may believe that he really didn't want to be there a bit more (and was only doing it as a favor). Making this changes would also extend the scene and build more tone to your characters.

Overall, I think you've made some really stellar changes to strength your chapter from the initial submission! I'm excited to keep in touch (because D&D forever) after graduation and see where you take this!

Best,

Sam

Kevin,

Nice work on this! I think you did a really great job in creating this mysterious world that Lucas travels through in his dreams. I could visualize what it looked like, and I could feel the sense of confusion he was feeling. It was a great opening scene for this chapter, and it helped to build the mystery of what is going on with Lucas. I also think you've really improved writing your dialogue and that shows in this chapter. I would note though, that sometimes when you put Lucas in situations where he's not speaking with someone (i.e. the opening scene, the illusion scene), some of the dialogue tends to sound a bit stilted/on the nose. I think this tends to happen with some of your internal dialogue as well. You do such a good job developing the voice in his dialogue when he's communicating with Jason, so try to focus on that voice and have it remain consistent throughout the rest of the story.

Something I didn't quite understand was Lucas's reaction to Jason telling him that he owed Caleb for forcing Caleb to tutor Lucas. Maybe this is expanded in the earlier chapters, and if so then that's totally fine, but I just felt like Lucas should be more upset about Caleb talking about him to Jason like that, especially if Lucas considers Caleb to be his closest friend at this place? I was upset on Lucas's behalf when he said that! Maybe I was misinterpreting that piece of dialogue, but if so, you might reconsider what Jason is saying during that conversation.

(This is a very very small side note, but I know you mentioned Caleb as a potential love interest for Lucas, so is Jason going to be like a love triangle/other potential love interest? Because I totally got that energy from this chapter and I am into it!!!)

Overall, I thought this chapter was a really nice improvement, and I really enjoyed it! Looking forward to our discussion tomorrow.

Julia

Emily’s Review of Kevin’s Chapter

Hi Kevin,

It looks like you have made some great revisions on this chapter so far. I am really glad that you added more description, especially regarding Jason’s character. Additionally, going more into depth about Lucas’ dreams in the beginning of the chapter was really useful and definitely cleared up any confusion I had.

One of the critiques I have about this chapter is how the other students view Lucas. Lucas is very clear that he doesn’t think the other students like him or want to be around him, yet I don’t really understand why. While I know it’s because he was the only one at the school born without powers, would that immediately make someone hated? I’m not sure how accepting this school is, but I find it really hard to believe his classmates hate him solely based on that. Maybe a student saw him speaking to one of his illusions and spread a rumor that he was crazy and weird? That would seem more believable.

Lastly, I really think you should be more specific about the interaction between Lucas and Jason. It seems as though Jason hardly helped him practice, but instead, was there for a matter of minutes. Did Jason just watch the same spell over and over? I think you should really expand upon this section. Add a bit more conversation between the two. I just think that the interaction was too quick, especially for a tutoring session. While I

understand Jason wasn’t a great tutor, I wanted to know so much more about both him, as well as the other power struggles Lucas is facing. Overall though, it is clear that you have really worked hard at improving this chapter. I’m excited to see the final product, good job!

Sydney Couval
Critique 3 for Kevin Casas
3/31/19

I really commend you for your rewrite of this chapter! I think the biggest improvement showed in the conversation with the illusion part. My biggest critique last time was that it seemed forced and awkward, and you made the transition seamless in this edit. It did not feel forced, and Lucas doesn't seem too weird for talking to an illusion. You also really showcased his anxiety and how that can permeate into all parts of life in an intrusive way. It was great writing and I think a lot of your intended audience will relate to those feelings. It is very clear that Lucas's inner quest will have something to do with getting a hold of his anxiety, and that feels very relevant in this day of age.

You also did a good job of giving Lucas a better motivation for going into the woods. You connected the beginning and ends of this chapter in a nice full circle way, and the situation seemed urgent enough that his running into the woods (even after the warning about the werewolf) seemed justified.

My biggest critique was that some elements still seemed a little corny, mainly the voice and some of the dialogue. "Learn… Grow…" just seemed too much like an inspirational poster. While I liked Lucas's internal dialogue, his conversation with Jason seemed too contrived. Lucas came across as very earnest, even though he thought that Jason didn't like him. I think that thinking that would make Lucas a little more reserved around him, and embarrassed to say something dumb or uncool. Jason comes across a little too much like a disney channel cool boy jock with his "snore fest" comment while sitting against a tree, but the conversation flows more as it commences. I thought that the ending part of their interaction was great, and showed how Jason might be nicer than we think. Overall, great work!

Kevin,

Wow! I think that this rewrite is truly fantastic and that you have organized your story in a concise way while embedding even more vivid imagery and details throughout. In particular, I love how this chapter begins with Lucas's dream of the voice and the maze. That line, "The dream, the maze, the voice" resonated with me and I'm certain it will also resonate with your young adult audience.

One critique I have is more so of a personal preference. On the bottom of page 3, I felt as though that question of paragraphs was a bit much to read and perhaps even a little redundant. Your writing is so descriptive and vivid that these questions are popping into the reader's minds naturally without you having to include them. I totally understand wanting to show what is occurring in Lucas's mind/possibilities of what these "dreams" could be about, but I feel as though this can be achieved without this paragraph of questions.

Moving forward throughout your chapter, I just wanted to note that Lucas's internal motivations and his relationships with the other characters are very clear and excellently demonstrated through your writing. In specific, I like how you really hone-in on and emphasize his relationship with Caleb and how he is quite clingy to him.

Overall, I really enjoyed reading this and feel that it is a complete, entirely well-done chapter!

Sincerely,

Juliana

Nathan Worob’s Review of Kevin’s Revised Chapter

I really enjoyed reading the second version of this chapter! It’s got a nice flow to it between the characters and the improvement from your original version definitely shows. I can really see how you’ve created a more hard magic system to the powers of the world, which I appreciate immensely. I think from personal experience that magic can never be hard systemized enough. And you’re doing excellently with that so far!

My biggest critique as of now is that the dialogue still feels disjointed from the story. Words like “snore fest” sort of took me out of what was happening in that they suggested the characters were behaving in ways not super characteristic of people their age. I suggest maybe toning down the sarcasm of the comments made and instead focusing on skepticism in order to pursue the same kind of dialogue goals that I think you’re aiming for.

Additionally, I recommend more worldbuilding. This critique might be a bit redundant given that you’ve already improved this area a great deal, or that other chapters were going to build on the same thing, but right now I think the story could use more time spent on both the positive and negative elements of such a magical system and surrounding world. I really like your world so far, and I look forward to reading more!